replacement and President's Rule was finally revoked on 17 October.[34]

The drama around Patil's public humiliation handed the BJP a vital opening: it created a new narrative of injured Lingayat pride. Around this time, the BJP's B.S. Yediyurappa, who had started as an RSS pracharak and entered politics with the Jan Sangh, was just beginning to establish his credentials as a Lingayat leader. Yediyurappa, then president of the party's state unit, declared that Patil's removal by Rajiv Gandhi was the 'most uncultured way to treat a chief minister'. He alleged that the communal riots that claimed forty lives and led to Patil's sacking had, in fact, been 'instigated' by a group of Congress leaders, led by C.K. Jaffer Sharief. According to Yediyurappa, Sharief had the Congress High Command's tacit approval for the 'coup' against Patil.[35]

A decade earlier, in neighbouring Andhra Pradesh, Telugu film actor N.T. Rama Rao had formed the TDP on a platform of regional sub-nationalism after Rajiv Gandhi, as Congress general secretary, publicly admonished the then Andhra chief minister Tanguturi Anjaiah in 1982 on the tarmac of Hyderabad's Begumpet airport. Gandhi had been annoyed by a crowd of partymen welcoming him with a band playing drums and other instruments. He was there on a private visit, and is said to have admonished Anjaiah, calling him a 'buffoon', when he learnt that the crowd was brought by the chief minister.[36] Patil himself indirectly compared his fall from grace at the airport with the Anjaiah incident. 'In this very state, and in next-door Andhra Pradesh, powerful chief ministers were humiliated at the polls because people thought they were corrupt,' he said in an interview. 'Unless Rajiv Gandhi gets rid of the power peddlers around him, his own political career will be finished.'[37]

A year after the Patil incident, in the 1991 parliamentary elections, the BJP opened its account in Karnataka, winning four seats. Patil, who remained opposed to the saffron party until he died, immediately saw the link. This was more about anti-Congress-ism and regional pride than religious identity. In an interview shortly after the 1991 election, he explained how the BJP's fortunes had suddenly changed. People were 'turning to the BJP', he said. 'During the last assembly poll [1989], the BJP was hard-pressed even to find